

Do you think this current system provides adequate accountability around short-term rentals in San Francisco? In your response, describe why you believe the system is adequate or inadequate. If you believe the system is inadequate, discuss a possible change in actions required to improve accountability in this system. You may refer to the SWE Code of Ethics as you think through your response.

I think the current system is inadequate because it is more reactive than proactive. The system relies on third-party investigators or neighbors to file complaints, and then they investigate the listing, which means the burden of enforcement and regulation falls on the public rather than the establishment. This allows many violations to go unnoticed and creates gaps in accountability, especially since Airbnb does not fully verify listing information before it is posted. In our own analysis, we saw incorrect policy numbers and missing ratings, showing that inaccurate data can exist on the platform. From the perspective of the SWE Code of Ethics, this fails to prioritize the public interest. A better approach would require Airbnb to validate policy numbers against official city records before allowing listings to go live, shifting responsibility back to the platform and improving accountability.

As discussed in the introduction, the legality of web scraping is still uncertain in the US. Skim through the Legal Issues section of Web Scraping in the US on Wikipedia and this article about the legal issues with the Computer Fraud and Abuse Act, and describe at least one factor you believe is important to consider when discussing the legality of web scraping and why.

An important factor in determining the legality of web scraping is the difference between publicly accessible data and authorized access under laws like the Computer Fraud and Abuse Act, since even publicly available data may still be restricted by a website's terms of service. Scraping can be used for beneficial purposes like transparency and accountability, but it can also expose individuals or organizations to big legal risk depending on how the data is collected. I think legality depends not only on whether the data is public, but also on whether the method of access respects legal boundaries.

Scraping public data does not always lead to positive results for society. For example, look to Facebook–Cambridge Analytica data scandal - Wikipedia or Clearview AI - Wikipedia. Many argue that using someone's personal data without their consent (even if publicly provided) is unethical. Web scraping requires thoughtful intervention. Develop at least two guidelines you think are important to consider when deciding whether to do web scraping.

Two important guidelines for ethical web scraping are respecting user privacy and ensuring a clear public benefit. First, even if data is publicly available, scraping should not collect or aggregate information in ways that violate user expectations or expose sensitive personal data.

Second, scraping should only happen when it serves a meaningful societal purpose, such as promoting transparency, research, or accountability, rather than for manipulation or exploitation.